1

"I saw all the snares of the enemy spread over the earth, and I said groaning, 'Who can escape such snares?' And I heard a voice saying to me, 'Humility.'"

St. Anthony the Great
Sayings of the Desert Fathers

2

"Go, sit in your cell, and your cell will teach you everything."

St. Moses the Black
Sayings of the Desert Fathers

3

"If you see a young man climbing to heaven by his own will, grab his foot and pull him down to the earth, for it is not profitable for him."

St. Macarius the Great
Sayings of the Desert Fathers

4

"Be like a bee: take the best from every flower and turn it into honey. And do not be like the fly that only lands on wounds."

St. Macarius the Great
Sayings of the Desert Fathers

5

"A brother asked Abba Poemen, 'What should I do about my sins?' The old man said, 'If you wish God to forgive you, forgive others. For it is written: Forgive and you will be forgiven.'"

Abba Poemen
Sayings of the Desert Fathers

6

"In the beginning there is struggle and a lot of work for those who come near to God. But after that, there is indescribable joy. It is just like building a fire: at first it is smoky and your eyes water, but later you get the desired result."

Amma Syncletica
Sayings of the Desert Mothers

7

"If someone speaks evil of you, do not hate him. Say, 'Because of my sins, God has permitted him to speak against me.' And God will turn his heart."

8

"Do not be always wanting everything to turn out as you think it should, but rather as God pleases, then you will be undisturbed and thankful in your prayer."

9

"A brother came to Abba Silvanus and was astonished to see him weeping. 'Why are you weeping, Father?' The old man said, 'Leave me, my son. I am weeping for my sins.' The brother said, 'But you are a holy man!' He replied, 'I do not know whether I have even begun to repent.'"

St. Moses the Black
Sayings of the Desert Fathers

Evagrius Ponticus
On Prayer

Abba Silvanus
Sayings of the Desert Fathers

10

"Just as it is impossible to see your face in troubled water, so also the soul, unless it is clear of alien thoughts, is not able to pray to God in contemplation."

St. Nilus of Sinai
On Prayer

11

"If you are stirred to anger, keep silent. And do not allow yourself to say anything until by prayer you have calmed yourself."

Abba Poemen
Sayings of the Desert Fathers

12

"An old man said: Every time a thought of superiority or vanity moves you, examine your conscience to see whether you have kept all the commandments. Do you love your enemies? Do you grieve at their failures? If not, do not count yourself as anything."

Desert Father (Anonymous)
Sayings of the Desert Fathers

13

"When Abba Macarius was returning to his cell from the marsh carrying palm-leaves, the devil met him with a sharp sickle and tried to strike him. He could not, and said, 'What power you have that I cannot overcome! Whatever you do, I do more. You fast, but I never eat. You keep vigil, but I never sleep. One thing only defeats me.' 'What is that?' asked Macarius. 'Your humility.'"

St. Macarius the Great
Sayings of the Desert Fathers

14

"There was an old man who fasted for seventy weeks, eating only once a week. He asked God about certain words of Holy Scripture, but God did not reveal them. He said, 'I will go to my brother and ask him.' As he locked the door to go out, an angel of the Lord was sent to him, saying, 'The seventy weeks of fasting did not bring you close to God, but when you humbled yourself to go to your brother, I was sent to tell you.'"

Desert Father (Anonymous)
Sayings of the Desert Fathers

15

"Even if we do not live in the desert, we can still be delivered if we eliminate the luxury of our thoughts."

Amma Syncletica
Sayings of the Desert Mothers

16

"Abba Lot went to see Abba Joseph and said, 'Father, I keep my little rule, my little fast, my prayer, meditation, and stillness, and as much as I can I keep my thoughts clean. What else should I do?' The old man stood up and stretched his hands toward heaven, and his fingers became like ten lamps of fire. He said, 'If you will, you can become all flame.'"

17

"It is better to eat meat and drink wine than to eat the flesh of your brothers through slander."

18

"Abba Anthony said: I no longer fear God, but I love Him. For love casts out fear."

Abba Joseph of Panephysis
Sayings of the Desert Fathers

Abba Hyperechius
Sayings of the Desert Fathers

St. Anthony the Great
Sayings of the Desert Fathers

19

"A brother asked Abba Poemen: 'How should I behave in my cell?' The old man said: 'Always have three things before your eyes: the fear of God, the memory of your death, and the judgment that is to come.'"

Abba Poemen
Sayings of the Desert Fathers

20

"A brother asked Amma Theodora, 'What must I do to be saved?' She said, 'Flee from the world. Sit in your cell and weep for your sins. Do not love to talk, for talk empties the heart.'"

Amma Theodora
Sayings of the Desert Mothers

21

"Abba Pambo asked Abba Anthony, 'What shall I do?' The old man replied, 'Do not trust in your own righteousness. Do not worry about a thing once it has been done. Control your tongue and your belly.'"

St. Anthony the Great
Sayings of the Desert Fathers

22

"A disciple asked, 'How can I find God?' The elder replied, 'Through fasting, prayer, and almsgiving.' The disciple asked, 'Is there nothing further?' The elder said, 'Not only should you fast, pray, and give alms, but if someone speaks evil of you, do not repay him with evil but with good.'"

Desert Father (Anonymous)
Sayings of the Desert Fathers

23

"If we see our brother in sin, we should not despise him, for there is a God who has mercy. If we see him in honor, we should not envy him, for there is a God who gives."

Abba Paphnutius
Sayings of the Desert Fathers

24

"A brother asked Abba Sisoes, 'What shall I do, Abba, for I have fallen?' The old man said, 'Get up again.' The brother said, 'I have got up, but I have fallen again.' The old man said, 'Get up again and again.' The brother asked, 'For how long?' The old man said, 'Until you are taken by death either in your fall or in your rising. For a person presents himself to God in the state in which he is found.'"

Abba Sisoes
Sayings of the Desert Fathers

25

"Abba Moses said: Sit in your cell and your cell will teach you everything. A fish that is taken out of water dies. So also a monk who stays outside his cell."

26

"There is no true prayer if a man is conscious that he is praying."

27

"A brother said to Abba Poemen: 'If I see my brother sin, is it right to say nothing about it?' The old man replied: 'Whenever we cover our brother's sin, God covers ours. Whenever we tell people about our brother's guilt, God reveals ours.'"

St. Moses the Black
Sayings of the Desert Fathers

St. Anthony the Great
Sayings of the Desert Fathers

Abba Poemen
Sayings of the Desert Fathers

28

"Once a brother committed a sin in Scetis, and the elders met and sent for Abba Moses. He refused to come. The priest sent again, saying, 'Come, for the assembly of brothers is waiting for you.' Abba Moses got up and came, carrying an old basket full of sand with holes in it. The elders asked, 'What is this, Father?' He said, 'My sins run out behind me, and I do not see them. And today I come to judge the sins of another?' They heard this, said nothing to the brother, and forgave him."

St. Moses the Black
Sayings of the Desert Fathers

29

"Amma Sarah said: If I prayed God that all people should approve of my conduct, I should find myself a penitent at the door of each one. But I shall rather pray that my heart may be pure toward all."

Amma Sarah
Sayings of the Desert Mothers

30

"Someone asked Abba Anthony: 'What must one do to please God?' The old man replied: 'Pay attention to what I tell you. Whoever you may be, always have God before your eyes. Whatever you do, do it according to the testimony of the Holy Scriptures. And wherever you live, do not easily leave.'"

St. Anthony the Great
Sayings of the Desert Fathers

31

"An old man was asked, 'How can I find God?' He said, 'In fasting, in watching, in labors. But above all these things, love God and your neighbor. For if anyone hates his neighbor, his labor is in vain.'"

Desert Father (Anonymous)
Sayings of the Desert Fathers

32

"The one who sits alone and is quiet has escaped from three wars: hearing, speaking, and seeing. But there is one thing against which he must continually fight: that is, his own heart."

St. Anthony the Great
Sayings of the Desert Fathers

33

"Abba John the Short said: We have thrown down the light burden, which is self-accusation, and taken up the heavy burden, which is self-justification."

Abba John the Short
Sayings of the Desert Fathers

34

"If you cannot contain yourself, let it be in solitude. If you cannot control your tongue among many, at least be silent with one. If you cannot be silent with one, at least be gentle."

35

"The devil does not know by what passion the soul is overcome. He sows but does not know if he will reap. He sows thoughts of fornication, slander, and other passions. Whichever passion the soul inclines to, that is the one he waters."

36

"Do not judge a fornicator if you are chaste, for you would then transgress the law just as much. For He who said 'Do not fornicate' also said 'Do not judge.'"

Amma Theodora
Sayings of the Desert Mothers

Abba Poemen
Sayings of the Desert Fathers

Abba Poemen
Sayings of the Desert Fathers

37

"Choose the meekness of Moses and you will find your heart, which is like a rock, changed into a spring of water."

Amma Syncletica
Sayings of the Desert Mothers

38

"An old man said: Do not judge him who is guilty of fornication if you are chaste. Do not judge him who is guilty of drunkenness if you are sober. Instead, say: He is my brother, and the temptation that overcame him may overcome me tomorrow."

Desert Father (Anonymous)
Sayings of the Desert Fathers

39

"A brother in Scetis went to ask Abba Moses for a word. The old man said to him, 'Go and sit in your cell, and your cell will teach you everything.' Silence is the great teacher."

St. Moses the Black
Sayings of the Desert Fathers

40

"Abba Anthony said: The time is coming when people will be seized by manias and will behave like madmen. And if they see anyone acting reasonably, they will rise up against him saying, 'You are insane,' because he is not like them."

St. Anthony the Great
Sayings of the Desert Fathers

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